Sub-Stantia

Dorsal Natality, Hypostatic Capital, and the Matricidal Image in Coralie Fargeat's The Substance

Toward a Feminism of the Substratum

A doctoral thesis in film philosophy and feminist theory

October 2026

...man is not truly one, but truly two.

Robert Louis Stevenson, *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886)

Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks.

Karl Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1 (1867), trans. Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling (1887)

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Abstract

Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance* (2024) has been received chiefly as a satire of ageism and beauty culture and as a feminist renewal of body horror. This thesis argues that it is more exactly a speculative ontology, one that literalizes the philosophical history sedimented in its title. *Substantia*, the Latin calque of the Greek *hypostasis* ("that which stands under") and the standard rendering of Aristotle's *ousia*, whose candidate sense in *Metaphysics* Z is the *hypokeimenon* ("that which lies under"), names the substratum of which qualities are predicated and which is itself predicated of nothing. Fargeat's fable divides a single life along precisely the vertical axis this word encodes. An upright, luminous, laboring figure, the "other self" called Sue, is sustained by a recumbent, aging, nourishing ground, the "matrix" Elisabeth Sparkle, from whose spinal column the figure's daily stabilizer is drawn. I name this arrangement **hypostatic extraction**, and the regime that organizes it, in which value is produced by dividing a life into a visible figure and an invisible substratum and transferring vitality upward from the second to the first, **hypostatic capital**.

The argument proceeds in six movements. Chapter One reads the product's commandment, "you are one," as a **liability monism** that ventriloquizes the Western metaphysics of identity: Aristophanes' severed halves in the *Symposium*, Jekyll's discovery that man is "not truly one, but truly two," the Nicene grammar of *ousia* and *hypostasis*, Spinoza's single substance, Locke's day-man and night-man, Parfit's fission, and Ricoeur's distinction between *idem* and *ipse*. Chapter Two develops a phenomenology of the back. Because the new self issues from the one region of the body its subject can never see, the film's founding image constitutes a **dorsal natality**, a birth from being-for-others (Sartre, Beauvoir, Berger, Husserl), staged across two antithetical mirror stages: Lacan's jubilant assumption of the specular image and Kathleen Woodward's "mirror stage of old age." Chapter Three reconstructs the seven-day "balance" as **the working week of the image**, reading Sue's encroachments through Marx's chapter on the working day, social-reproduction feminism, Crary on sleep, Han's

achievement-subject, and Preciado's pharmacopornographic regime; it argues that the film inverts the vampire genealogy, since what the young image consumes is not youth but accumulated time, a structure I term **gerontophagy**. Chapter Four reads the narrative as a **matricidal ontology**, situating Sue's killing of the matrix between Kristeva's "vital" symbolic matricide and Irigaray's thesis that Western culture is founded on the murder of the mother, and recasts the finale as an Oresteia of the image in which the Furies return as Monstro ElisaSue. Chapter Five argues that the Substance kit is the cinematic apparatus rendered biological: Benjamin's mirror image made "separable" and "transportable," the Egyptian *ka* sustained by its mummy in the joint sense of Bazin and Morin, a Fayum portrait laid over a ruined face. Chapter Six confronts the film's humanist inheritance (Pico, Kant's distinction between price and dignity, Arendt's natality, Nussbaum's anatomies of objectification and disgust) and its transhumanist horizon, concluding that the film diagnoses the completion of Renaissance self-fashioning as commodity self-replication.

Against the film's terminal horizontality, the dissolution of its heroine's remnant upon her Hollywood Walk of Fame star and its erasure by a street-cleaning machine at dawn, the Conclusion proposes a **hypostatic feminism**: an ethics, politics, and aesthetics of the substratum that grants value to the recumbent, the resting, the aged, and the unseen. It is assembled from Le Guin's crone and carrier bag, Kittay's dependency ethics, Greer's climacteric, Cixous's laughing Medusa, and Marx's observation that the limits of the working day are secured collectively or not at all.

Lexicon of Terms

The following neologisms are introduced and defended in the chapters indicated; they are gathered here for reference.

Introduction; Chapter Three

Hypostatic extraction. The transfer of vitality, time, or value from a recumbent, invisible substratum to an upright, visible figure constituted out of the same life. In the film: the daily drawing of spinal fluid from the matrix to stabilize Sue.

Introduction; Chapter Three

Hypostatic capital. The general regime, at once economic, patriarchal, and cinematic, that produces value by dividing a life into figure and ground, capitalizing the figure while charging its costs to the ground.

Chapter Two

Dorsal natality. A birth that issues from the back: from the region of the body its subject can never see and that belongs, phenomenologically, to others. Dorsal natality is therefore a birth from being-for-others, and it is the counterfeit of Arendtian natality, since it begins nothing that was not already valued.

Chapter One

Liability monism. The corporate metaphysics expressed in "you are one": an insistence on numerical identity precisely where the product manufactures numerical duality, whose function is to assign all consequences of the division to the purchaser.

Chapter Three

The working week of the image. The seven-day alternation of the "balance," read as a normal working day in Marx's sense, whose extension by the image constitutes the film's central conflict.

Chapter Three

Gerontophagy. The consumption of the old by the young image, reversing the vampire genealogy of the Blood Countess and of "young blood": the image already possesses youth; what it devours is the accumulated time, reputation, and property of the aged body.

Chapter Two

Evaluative proximity. Fargeat's signature close-up: a camera distance too short for personhood, applied without distinction to the eroticized body, the patriarch's chewing mouth, and the aging

hand, which thereby reveals the erotic and the abject close-up as a single operation of appraisal.

Chapter Four

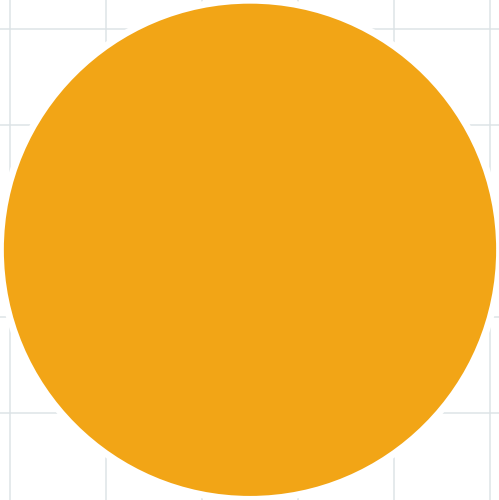
Matricidal ontology. A conception of selfhood in which the new self can constitute itself only by killing the body from which it issued, and cannot survive that killing.

Chapter Five

Dialectical hagsploitation. The film's relation to the "Grande Dame Guignol" cycle: it reactivates the genre's conversion of aging actresses into monsters in order to expose the economy that performs the conversion, without being able wholly to escape the pleasure the genre has always taken in it.

Conclusion

Hypostatic feminism. An ethics, politics, and aesthetics of the substratum, organized around five theses: the ground is the condition rather than the residue of the figure; rest is a right of the ground; the back belongs to the other, so that the proper relation to the unseen self is care rather than gaze; the crone is the measure; and horizontality may be solidarity rather than dissolution.



Introduction

The Problem of the Title

Yolk and star, literalization as method, and the thesis of hypostatic extraction.

I.1 Two Prologues: The Yolk and the Star

The Substance opens not with a woman but with a yolk. On a white ground a syringe pierces an egg yolk, injects a phosphorescent fluid, and withdraws; a second yolk swells out of the first and comes to rest beside it. The image is a micrograph of reproductive technology enlarged to the scale of a kitchen. Its composition rhymes with the canonical photograph of intracytoplasmic sperm injection, the pipette entering the oocyte, and so inaugurates the film within the iconography of the "biological clock" that assisted reproduction promises to defeat. Yet its zoology is more precise than its iconography. The yolk, the *vitellus*, is not the embryo but the embryo's reserve: the nutritive substance on which the growing organism feeds until it has consumed it. In a single shot Fargeat states the economy of everything that follows. A new life is generated by injection; it emerges whole, without gestation or infancy; and it lives on a reserve that it will exhaust.

The second prologue relocates the same economy from biology to fame. A star bearing the name Elisabeth Sparkle is set into the Hollywood Walk of Fame, consecrated before cameras and applause, and then, in a time-lapse that compresses decades, abandoned to the traffic of the street: trodden, cracked, splashed with the debris of fast food, ignored. The sequence is usually read as an emblem of fame's transience. It is more exact to read it as a definition. The Walk of Fame is a pavement; its stars are set beneath the feet of the crowd; to be consecrated there is, literally, to become that upon which others stand. The star is a *sub-stance* in the etymological sense.

Between the yolk and the star the film has already distinguished the two senses of "substance" that its narrative will fuse in one woman: substance as that which nourishes, the reserve consumed by what grows from it, and substance as that which bears, the ground on which the figure stands. Elisabeth Sparkle will be both: the reserve from which Sue feeds and the pavement on which Sue's celebrity is erected.

I.2 The Film and the Limits of Its Reception

Written and directed by Fargeat, *The Substance* premiered in competition at Cannes in May 2024, where it received the award for Best Screenplay; it later received the Academy Award for Best Makeup and Hairstyling. Demi Moore plays Elisabeth Sparkle, a former film star reduced to hosting a televised aerobics programme; Margaret Qualley plays Sue; Dennis Quaid plays Harvey, the network executive who discards Elisabeth on her fiftieth birthday. After a car accident, a young nurse slips a drive into her coat advertising a clandestine product. Its protocol is lapidary. A single-use "activator" generates a younger "other self" from the body of the user, henceforth called the "matrix"; a "stabilizer" extracted from the matrix's spinal fluid must be taken daily to keep the other self coherent; the unconscious matrix must be nourished intravenously; and the two must "switch" every seven days "without exception," under the injunction to "respect the balance" and the reminder that "you are one."

To be consecrated there is, literally, to become that upon which others stand.

Sue emerges from a vertical rupture along Elisabeth's spine, sutures the wound, and is hired by Harvey as the face of a new programme. She begins to overstay her week, drawing extra stabilizer; each excess is paid for by the matrix in sudden, localized senescence, first in a single index finger, then across the whole body. Elisabeth attempts to terminate the arrangement, aborts the attempt, and is beaten to death by the revived Sue. Deprived of her source, Sue decomposes; she injects the remaining activator and produces Monstro ElisaSue, a composite creature that attends the network's New Year's Eve broadcast wearing a paper mask cut from a photograph of Elisabeth's younger face. Unmasked before the studio audience, the creature is set upon and becomes a fountain of blood that drenches the crowd. Its remnant, Elisabeth's face upon a mass of undifferentiated flesh, drags itself to the Walk of Fame star, lies down upon it, and dissolves; at dawn a mechanical street cleaner washes it away.

The film's reception has been organized by three frames. The first reads it as a satire of the beauty industry and of Hollywood ageism. The second situates it in the genealogy of body horror, between Cronenberg's "new flesh" and the French corporeal cinema of Marina de Van and Julia Ducournau. The third, often voiced as reproach, finds it unsubtle and suspects it of reproducing the objectifying gaze it claims to indict. Each frame captures something; none is adequate. The first mistakes an ontology for a satire, since the film is less concerned with the cosmetics market than with the structure of value of which that market is one expression. The second tracks the film's genre without its metaphysics. The third mistakes its method.

I.3 Method I: Literalization

Fargeat's procedure is the systematic revivification of dead metaphors. The clichés in which a culture speaks of women's aging are each, in turn, made flesh. A woman who has "let herself go" is shown literally releasing a second self into the world. The "shadow of her former self" becomes a body that wanes as its double waxes. To "lose one's backbone" is to have one's spinal fluid extracted; to be "eaten alive" by ambition is to be metabolized by one's own image; to become "one's own worst enemy" is to be beaten to death by oneself; to be offered "a better version of yourself" is to be offered a replacement. Even the network's demand for a new "face" for its programme is answered with a face that can be cut out, worn, and peeled away.

This is not subtlety's failure but its refusal, and the refusal has a theoretical lineage. Deleuze and Guattari argued that Kafka deliberately kills metaphor, and that Gregor Samsa's metamorphosis is the contrary of a metaphor: not a figure for alienation but its literal occurrence. Fargeat's cinema belongs to this lineage. Subtlety is the regime in which the violence done to bodies is kept figurative, legible only to the interpreter; literalization withdraws the anaesthetic that figuration supplies. The discomfort of which the film's detractors complain is that withdrawal registered in the spectator's body. When the violence a culture practises upon women in metaphor is returned to the

literal, it ceases to be deniable, and it is this undeniability, rather than any deficit of nuance, that viewers experience as excess.

I.4 Method II: Constellation and the Three Orders of Relation

The thesis refers the film to the originators of the ideas it embodies, but it distinguishes three orders of relation, since to conflate them would be to substitute allusion-hunting for argument. The first is documented influence: Fargeat's acknowledged debts to Cronenberg, Kubrick, Lynch, and Carpenter, and the continuities with her own short *Reality+* (2014), in which a neural implant renders its users ideally beautiful to themselves and to one another for strictly limited periods, and with *Revenge* (2017), a rape-revenge film whose heroine, Jen, is raped by one of her married lover's friends, pushed from a cliff by the lover himself and left for dead, and survives by cauterizing her own wound, which brands the image of a phoenix into her skin. The second is generic genealogy: the Hollywood self-portraits of the discarded star (*Sunset Boulevard*, *All About Eve*), the "Grande Dame Guignol" cycle inaugurated by *What Ever Happened to Baby Jane?*, and the B-movie rejuvenation horrors (*The Wasp Woman*, *The Leech Woman*) whose plots *The Substance* reprises almost point for point. The third, and for this thesis the most important, is elective affinity, in the sense Goethe gave the chemists' term and Weber transposed into social theory: a relation between texts that did not need to know one another in order to think together.

The method appropriate to the third order is what Benjamin, in the epistemo-critical prologue to his study of the German *Trauerspiel*, called the constellation: ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars. The analogy is hardly incidental to a film about a star. A star, in Benjamin's figure, becomes legible only within the configuration it shares with others; the task of criticism is to draw the lines between them. This thesis draws the lines between Elisabeth Sparkle's star and the theoretical bodies, from Aeschylus to Preciado, that render its configuration visible.

I.5 Thesis

The film's technical vocabulary is already a philosophy. "Matrix" derives from *mater*, mother, and designated in Latin the womb and the breeding animal; in the arts of reproduction it names the die from which coins are struck, the mould from which type is cast, the master from which records are pressed, the negative from which prints are made. The matrix is at once mother and master copy, the source of offspring and the source of reproductions. The "stabilizer" derives from *stare*, to stand, and its function is to keep the figure standing. The "balance" is the scale of justice and of commodity exchange, the instrument of equivalence. The "switch" is a transfer of consciousness between bodies; "termination" belongs simultaneously to contract law, to obstetrics, and to execution. And "the substance," the product's only name, is the oldest term of Western metaphysics for that which underlies.

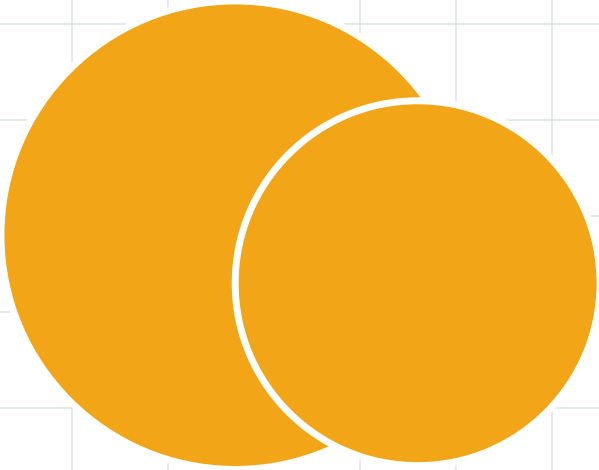
I propose that the film be read as a speculative ontology of **hypostatic extraction**: a regime in which a single life is divided into a figure that stands and a ground that lies beneath it, and in which the figure lives only by drawing continuously upon the ground's vital reserve. Patriarchal visuality, capitalist value-production, and the cinematic apparatus are, on this reading, three faces of one regime, which I call **hypostatic capital**, and the film's achievement is to show them operating in a single act: the drawing of fluid from a sleeping woman's spine. Every major structure of the film is organized along the vertical axis this implies. Sue stands; the matrix lies. The billboard is vertical; the Walk of Fame star is horizontal. Extraction is performed upon the spine, the anatomical axis of uprightness, and aging is figured as a progressive loss of uprightness, the matrix's back bending into a hump. Death, finally, is pure horizontality: a puddle on a pavement.

The Conclusion turns this diagnosis into a proposal. If the regime that destroys Elisabeth capitalizes the standing figure and charges its costs to the recumbent ground, then a feminism adequate to it must be a feminism of the ground, a **hypostatic feminism**, which refuses to measure value by uprightness, visibility, and youth.

I.6 Plan of the Thesis

Chapter One examines the film's metaphysics of identity, reading "you are one" against the philosophical history of the one and the two. Chapter Two develops the phenomenology of the gaze and of the back on which the concept of dorsal natality rests. Chapter Three reconstructs the film's political economy as the working week of the image. Chapter Four offers a psychoanalytic and mythographic reading of the narrative as a matricide. Chapter Five reads the Substance as the cinematic apparatus rendered biological and situates the film within its generic genealogy. Chapter Six measures the film against the humanist tradition and its posthumanist successors, and states the limits of the film's own feminism. The Conclusion articulates the five theses of hypostatic feminism.

1



Chapter One

The Theology of the One

"You are one" as liability monism, from Aristophanes to Parfit and Ricoeur.

1.1 “You Are One”: Liability Monism

The Substance speaks in two registers. Its advertisement speaks the language of aspiration: a better version of yourself, younger, more beautiful, more perfect. Its customer service speaks the language of doctrine. When Elisabeth telephones to complain, an impassive male voice returns the same proposition, “you are one,” with the finality of a catechism. The proposition is false on its face. The product exists to manufacture numerical duality: two bodies, two schedules, two sets of memories, two careers, two appetites. The question is therefore not whether the proposition is true but what it does.

What it does is assign liability. If the matrix and the other self are one, then every harm the other self inflicts upon the matrix is self-inflicted, every encroachment a failure of self-discipline, and no grievance can be lodged against the supplier. “You are one” is the metaphysics of a terms-of-service agreement. It belongs to the family of discourses that Foucault, in his lectures on neoliberalism, identified with the reinvention of *homo economicus* as an entrepreneur of himself, and that Wendy Brown later analyzed as responsibilization: the transfer of systemic risk to individuals who are then held solely accountable for outcomes they do not control. I call the doctrine **liability monism**. It asserts unity at the level of responsibility while producing division at every other level, and the film’s horror lives in the gap between the two.

Liability monism is not a new invention but the latest occupant of a very old position. The proposition that the many are secretly one, or that the one is secretly two, is among the founding problems of Western thought. The remainder of this chapter reconstructs six moments of that history, each of which the film reanimates, and argues that the Substance’s slogan compresses them into a single commercial formula.

1.2 The Severed Halves: Aristophanes

In Plato’s *Symposium*, Aristophanes recounts that human beings were once double: round creatures with four arms, four legs, and two faces looking in opposite directions. Because their strength

made them presumptuous, Zeus cut them in half. Apollo then turned each half's face toward the wound, drew the loose skin together over the belly, and tied it at the navel, which remains as a memorial of the division. Ever since, each half has sought its other, and the desire and pursuit of the whole is called love.

Fargeat's fable restages the myth with three decisive inversions. First, the division is not a punishment but a purchase; it is undergone not for hubris but for employability. Second, the suture is performed not by a god but by the severed half itself: Sue, newly born, stitches the long wound in Elisabeth's back with needle and thread. Third, the scar is not on the belly but on the back. Aristophanes placed the memorial of division where its bearer could see it, so that the navel would remind us of what we lost. The Substance places it where its bearer cannot see it, so that the division is inscribed on the body without ever entering its owner's field of vision.

The myth also clarifies the film's ending. Aristophanic love is the longing to restore the double being. Monstro ElisaSue, with its multiplied faces, displaced breasts, and supernumerary limbs, is that being restored: the round creature reassembled, not by love but by desperation, from two halves that had come to hate each other. The film thereby turns the oldest myth of eros into a demonstration that, under hypostatic capital, wholeness is not the cure for division but its final symptom. The longed-for One returns as the monster.

1.3 "Not Truly One, but Truly Two": Stevenson

The Substance is a pharmaceutical *Jekyll and Hyde*, and the resemblance extends to details. In *Henry Jekyll's Full Statement of the Case*, Jekyll records his conviction that man is not truly one, but truly two, and describes the compound that separates the two. His other self, Edward Hyde, is smaller, slighter, and younger than Jekyll. As Jekyll indulges the transformation, Hyde grows in vigour, the changes become involuntary, and Jekyll observes that he is slowly losing hold of his original and better self and becoming slowly incorporated with his second and worse. The supply finally fails, since the original salt contained an impurity that no fresh batch reproduces, and Jekyll is trapped in the body of his double.

Under hypostatic capital, wholeness is not the cure for division but its final symptom.

Fargeat preserves the structure and inverts its moral coordinates. Stevenson's second self is the release of appetite from Victorian discipline; Fargeat's second self is discipline incarnate, a body formed entirely by the regime of fitness, cosmetics, and camera. The "better" self, in the market's vocabulary, is precisely the one Jekyll called "worse": the younger, more vigorous one, whose growth is paid for by the withering of its host. Appetite, meanwhile, is displaced onto the matrix. During her weeks Elisabeth cooks and eats with a fury that the film shoots as obscenity. The duality remains, but it has been redistributed: the image is hungry for time and visibility, the body for food. Both are insatiable, and each regards the other's hunger as the threat.

The slogan "you are one" can now be read as a direct reply to Jekyll. Jekyll's discovery licensed a fantasy of moral irresponsibility, since Hyde's crimes were not his. The Substance's doctrine reimposes responsibility while keeping the duality. Its users receive the Jekyll fantasy as a product and the Jekyll guilt as a contract.

1.4 Ousia and Hypostasis: The Grammar of the Substratum

The product's name points behind both Plato and Stevenson to the technical vocabulary of ancient metaphysics. In the *Categories*, Aristotle defines primary substance (*ousia*) as that which is neither said of a subject nor present in a subject: the individual of which everything else is predicated. In *Metaphysics* Z he considers, and qualifies, the candidacy of the *hypokeimenon*, the substratum, "that which lies under" all predication. The film arranges its two bodies according to this grammar. All the predicates the market values (young, beautiful, desirable, successful) are said of Sue. But the subject of which they are ultimately predicated, the reserve from which they are drawn, lies beneath, unconscious, on the tiled floor of a hidden room. The matrix is the *hypokeimenon*: literally, the one who lies under.

The Latin tradition rendered *hypokeimenon* as *subiectum*, the root of the modern "subject." Heidegger argued in "The Age of the

World Picture" that modernity is the epoch in which man becomes the *subiectum*, the relational centre for whom the world is conquered as picture. *The Substance* stages the reversal of that history. In the age of the image the subject is not the one who represents the world as picture but the one who is represented, and the archaic sense of *subiectum* returns: the subject is demoted to substratum, the support beneath a picture that has become the self.

A second terminological history is equally pertinent. The fourth-century Trinitarian settlement produced the formula of one *ousia* in three *hypostaseis*, one substance in distinct persons, together with the term *homoousios*, "of the same substance," for the Son's relation to the Father; the Latin West, which used *substantia* for *ousia*, was long unsettled by the fact that *substantia* is the literal calque of *hypostasis*. The Substance markets a degraded binitarianism: one substance, two persons, the begotten declared consubstantial with the begetter. Its practice, however, is Arianism in reverse. The Arians held the Son subordinate to the Father; in the Substance the begotten subordinates the begetter and lives by consuming her. The film takes the most elaborate apparatus Western thought ever built for thinking one-in-many without subordination and shows it repurposed as an apparatus of subordination within a single person.

1.5 One Substance or Two: Descartes and Spinoza

The kit's operational metaphysics is Cartesian. Descartes distinguished two substances, thinking and extended, and the weekly "switch" presupposes exactly this partition: a consciousness transferable between two extended bodies without remainder. Its slogan, however, is Spinozist. Spinoza held that there is only one substance, of which all particular things are modes, and that each thing strives, as far as it can by its own power, to persevere in its being. The Substance sells a Cartesian product in Spinozist language, and the contradiction is the plot.

Read from the Spinozist side, the film is a tragedy of two *conatus* in one substance. Sue's striving to persevere in her being (her career, her visibility, her week) is achieved by diminishing Elisabeth's power to persevere in hers, and conversely. Spinoza's

insight that whatever affects a mode affects the substance of which it is a mode is the hidden truth of "you are one." What Sue does to Elisabeth she does to the substance that is also herself, and her killing of Elisabeth is accordingly a suicide. The corporate slogan is metaphysically correct and practically irrelevant: true at the level of substance and useless at the level of modes, where all lived experience takes place.

1.6 Day-Man and Night-Man: Locke and Parfit

Personal identity theory supplies the most exact account of why the halves come to hate each other. In the chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694), Locke locates personal identity in consciousness rather than in substance, and imagines the same man possessed of distinct and incommunicable consciousnesses by day and by night. Such a Day-man and Night-man, he concludes, would be as distinct persons as Socrates and Plato. *The Substance* builds Locke's thought experiment into its protocol. Elisabeth and Sue never experience each other's weeks; each learns of the other only through traces: a disordered kitchen, a televised broadcast, a finger aged overnight. By Locke's criterion they are two persons sharing one man, and their hostility is the logic of persons compelled to share a single resource.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) generalizes the point through the case of fission, in which a person divides into two successors, each psychologically continuous with the original. Parfit argued that identity is not what matters in survival; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, which he called Relation R, and which holds in degrees. The Substance is a Parfitian experiment conducted under commercial conditions. At the moment of division, Sue and Elisabeth are maximally R-related: Sue knows the apartment, the protocol, the life. Every week thereafter connectedness diminishes, as each accumulates experiences the other lacks, and with it diminishes the only thing that could have grounded mutual concern. "You are one" asserts the persistence of a numerical identity that Parfit showed to be empty, at precisely the moment when the relation that matters is decaying.

There is a further irony. Parfit reported that his reductionist view of persons liberated him: the walls of the glass tunnel in which he had seemed to live disappeared, and he cared less about his own continued existence. The Substance also reduces the person to separable components, but the reduction intensifies rather than dissolves self-concern. What Parfit experienced as liberation from the self, the market reproduces as a multiplication of the self's anxieties: two bodies to maintain, two careers to protect, two deaths to fear.

1.7 Idem and Ipse: The Broken Promise to Oneself

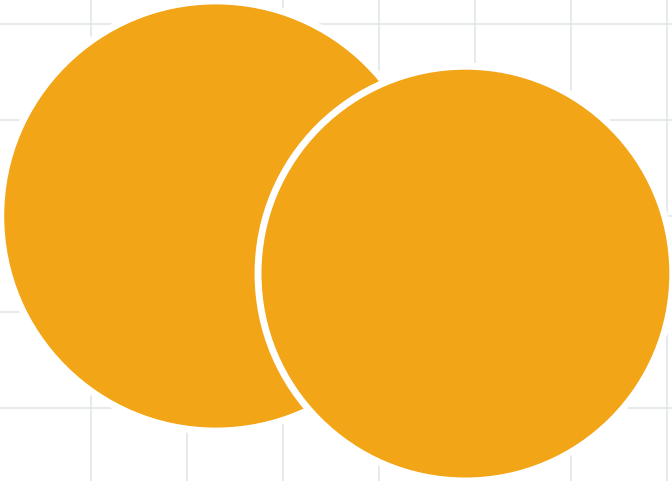
Paul Ricoeur's *Oneself as Another* (1990) distinguishes two senses of identity: *idem*, sameness, the permanence of a thing in time; and *ipse*, selfhood, whose paradigm is the kept promise, by which a self maintains itself across change through fidelity to its word. "Respect the balance" is a demand for *ipse*. It asks two bodies that share no *idem* to remain one self by honouring a vow, and the film's central transgression, Sue's overstaying, is a broken promise to oneself. But such a breach presupposes the very structure named in Ricoeur's title. One can break a promise to oneself only if oneself has become another, and the Substance makes that condition literal. Ricoeurian self-constancy becomes, under hypostatic capital, an impossible demand: that a self divided by the market's evaluative gaze keep, unassisted, a promise whose breaking is precisely what the market rewards. Harvey does not punish Sue for overstaying; he gives her the New Year's Eve broadcast.

Ricoeur's concept of narrative identity explains Elisabeth's distinctive suffering. A self, for Ricoeur, is constituted by its capacity to configure its life as a narrated whole. Elisabeth loses that capacity. Half of her life now unfolds in weeks to which she has no access, and she can know her own career only as a spectator of televised images. Her biography has become unnarratable from the inside.

A final observation belongs to onomastic play rather than to authorial intention, but it is too exact to omit. The Hebrew *Elisheva*, from which Elisabeth descends, is conventionally glossed "my God is an oath." The matrix bears a name that means a vow. Her double bears a name that is also a verb: to sue is to petition, to court, and

to bring an action at law. The film's vocabulary of liability finds an unwitting echo in its names. The one who keeps the oath lies under; the one who sues stands.

2



Chapter Two

The Surveyor and the Surveyed

The gaze, the back, and a self born from its being-for-others.

2.1 Berger: The Split Made Flesh

The most exact anticipation of Fargeat's premise is not a work of horror but a television series and the book that accompanied it. In *Ways of Seeing* (1972), John Berger argued that a woman in patriarchal culture is split in two. She must continually watch herself; she is almost always accompanied by her own image of herself; and she comes to regard the surveyor and the surveyed within her as the two constituent yet always distinct elements of her identity. Berger's formula for the asymmetry, that men act and women appear, is completed by a further claim: the surveyor of woman in herself is male, and the surveyed is female.

The Substance takes Berger at his word and distributes the two elements between two bodies. Sue is the surveyed: a body that exists to appear, whose waking hours are spent before cameras, mirrors, executives, and audiences. Elisabeth becomes the surveyor: during her weeks she watches Sue on television and on a colossal billboard visible from her window, and appraises her with a ferocity indistinguishable from Harvey's. The film thereby makes visible the second half of Berger's thesis. The surveyor in Elisabeth is male in the sense Berger intended: not that a man is present, but that the criteria by which she evaluates the image are the criteria of the executive who discarded her. When Elisabeth looks at Sue, Harvey looks through her eyes.

Berger's argument passes through a painting whose subject the film all but names. In the pages of *Ways of Seeing* that reproduce Tintoretto's *Susanna and the Elders*, Berger observes of the European tradition that a painter who placed a mirror in a naked woman's hand and titled the picture *Vanity* morally condemned the woman whose nakedness he had painted for his own pleasure; the mirror's real function was to make the woman connive in treating herself as, first and foremost, a sight. In the story, one of the Greek additions to the Book of Daniel, Susanna is a young married woman whom two elders, appointed that year as judges of the community, spy upon as she bathes. They demand that she submit to them sexually, threatening otherwise to testify that they caught her in adultery with a young man, a capital charge; she refuses, they carry out the threat, and she is condemned to death until Daniel exposes

their perjury by questioning them apart. Fargeat's young self is called Sue, and her audition takes place before a panel of aging male executives whose appraisal the camera renders in leering close-up. The film shows these men exercising their power through appraisal and dismissal rather than extortion, but it is the Elders' power: a woman's standing made to depend on the word of the men who look at her. Whether or not the echo is intended, the art-historical tradition supplies the film with its primal scene: Susanna and the Elders transposed to a network boardroom.

The same tradition supplies the counter-tradition. Artemisia Gentileschi's *Susanna and the Elders* (1610), painted when she was about seventeen, refuses the voyeuristic pleasure of the male versions: her Susanna twists away in distress, and the Elders loom as an oppressive weight bearing down upon her. The next year Gentileschi was raped by Agostino Tassi, a painter her father had engaged to teach her perspective. At the trial of 1612 it was her body and her word that were examined: she was subjected to a gynaecological examination and questioned under torture with thumbscrews to test her testimony, while Tassi, though convicted, never served his sentence of exile from Rome. Her life repeated the painting's structure as institutional procedure, the woman examined and the men's word presumed. Fargeat's project is Artemisia's: to depict the subject of the gaze while denying the gazers their pleasure. Whether she succeeds is the question of the next section.

2.2 Evaluative Proximity: The Gaze Debate Adjudicated

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) identified in classical cinema a structure in which woman connotes "to-be-looked-at-ness," and in which the camera, the male protagonist, and the spectator converge in a look that fragments the female body into fetishized parts. Sue's aerobics programme is a deliberate compendium of this structure. The camera isolates buttocks, crotch, and breasts in tight framings synchronized to the music's beat, a fragmentation so systematic that it becomes the programme's visual signature. Critics who accuse the film of reproducing the gaze describe these shots accurately. The question is what the shots do within the system of the film.

Three answers have been available. The first, derived from Luce Irigaray, holds that hyperbolic mimicry can convert a subordination into an affirmation: to play deliberately with mimesis is to occupy the place of one's exploitation by discourse without being simply reduced to it, exposing through excess the operation the norm conceals. The second, derived from Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) and Mary Ann Doane's "Film and the Masquerade" (1982), holds that femininity flaunted as masquerade opens a distance between the woman and her image that the spectator may inhabit critically. The third, sceptical, holds that hyperbole does not cancel pleasure, and that a spectator may enjoy the shots while congratulating himself on his critical distance.

When Elisabeth looks at Sue, Harvey looks through her eyes.

The film's own answer is subtler than any of the three, and it lies in what I call **evaluative proximity**. Fargeat does not reserve her extreme close-ups for the eroticized body. The same lens, at the same distance, is applied to Harvey's mouth tearing at shrimp, to the grease on his fingers, to the swollen knuckle of the matrix's aged finger, and to the gelatinous surface of the yolk. The film refuses to divide its close-ups into an erotic and a grotesque register. The consequence is that the spectator cannot enjoy the first without having been trained, by the same optical operation, to feel disgust in the second. The erotic close-up and the abject close-up are revealed as one operation: the appraisal of flesh at a distance too short for personhood.

Béla Balázs believed the close-up disclosed the microphysiognomy of the soul, the play of interiority across the surface of a face. Fargeat's close-up discloses no soul, only the surface on which value is assessed. It is an anti-Balázsian close-up, and its effect is not to cancel the gaze's pleasure but to charge for it, subsequently and in the same currency, at its full price.

2.3 Being-for-Others and the Unrealizable

The phenomenological ground of Berger's split is Sartre's analysis of the look in *Being and Nothingness* (1943). Under the gaze of another I discover a dimension of my being that I am but cannot know from within: my being-for-others, an outside that the other possesses and I do not. Sartre called such determinations, which I am for others without being able to experience them as mine, *unrealizables*. Simone de Beauvoir, in *Old Age* (1970), argued that old age is the unrealizable par excellence. It is the Other within me who is old: I learn that I am old from the way others regard me, and I cannot coincide with that verdict from inside, since inwardly I remain myself.

Elisabeth's trajectory begins exactly here. She is not old in any sense she can feel. She is told that she is old, by Harvey, over lunch, on her fiftieth birthday, and the verdict precedes any bodily sign. She is, in Margaret Morganroth Gullette's phrase, aged by culture before she is aged by time. The Substance's genius is to make the unrealizable realizable. The matrix ages exactly to the extent that Sue's being-for-others requires: each surplus day of Sue's visibility is paid for by a sudden, localized senescence in Elisabeth's body. The verdict that Beauvoir described as forever exterior to the self is thereby converted into a body the self must inhabit every other week. The Other within becomes the flesh within. Beauvoir's unrealizable is realized, and its realization is the horror.

2.4 The Back: A Phenomenology of the Unseen Side

Husserl observed in *Ideas II* that the lived body, the organ of all perception, is itself a remarkably imperfectly constituted thing: it obstructs its own perception, and certain of its regions are permanently withheld from my sight. The paradigmatic such region is the back. I can see my hands, my legs, the front of my torso; I cannot see my back except in a mirror or through the eyes of another. The back is the part of my body that belongs to others.

This is why the site of Sue's birth is not incidental but structural. Sue emerges through a vertical rupture along Elisabeth's spine: from the one region of Elisabeth's body that Elisabeth cannot see,

and that only others can. I call this event **dorsal natality**. The new self is born from the body's being-for-others, from the side of the body that faces the world and not the self. The film's choreography confirms the reading. After the birth Elisabeth cannot tend the wound; she cannot see it and cannot reach it. Only the other self can close it, and Sue does so while Elisabeth lies unconscious. The back is the site where we are necessarily cared for, or harmed, by others; the Substance makes it the site where one is harmed, and minimally repaired, by oneself as another. The film is saturated with the moral idioms of the dorsal and literalizes each of them: to be stabbed in the back, to have something done behind one's back, to turn one's back on oneself, to have or to lack backbone.

The spine adds a second register. Erwin Straus argued in "The Upright Posture" (1952) that standing is not a mere anatomical fact but a constitutive mode of human existence, the posture through which the human being gains distance from the ground and confronts the world as world. *Status* derives from *stare*, to stand. The Substance draws its stabilizer from the vertebral column, the anatomical axis of standing, and the matrix pays for each excess with a loss of uprightness. Her posture collapses; her back curves into what clinical folk-language, with its own ageist cruelty, calls a dowager's hump. The film's political anatomy is thereby complete. Value is uprightness. Extraction is performed upon the axis of uprightness. Aging is the loss of uprightness. Social standing is drawn, literally, from the spine.

2.5 Two Mirror Stages

Jacques Lacan's "mirror stage" describes the moment, between six and eighteen months, at which the infant jubilantly assumes its specular image as an ideal unity, an orthopaedic totality anticipating a coordination its fragmented motor body does not yet possess. The ego is founded on this *méconnaissance*: the self is first an image, and an alienating one. Kathleen Woodward, in *Aging and Its Discontents* (1991), proposed a "mirror stage of old age" as Lacan's inverse. The aging subject sees in the mirror an image she refuses to recognize as her own; the specular image no longer anticipates a unity the body lacks but announces a decline the self disowns. Woodward reads a now-famous footnote to Freud's essay

on the uncanny, in which Freud, travelling in a sleeping compartment, saw an elderly gentleman in a dressing-gown enter, rose to set him right, and realized that the intruder was his own reflection in the looking-glass on the connecting door; he recalled thoroughly disliking the man's appearance.

The Substance is constructed around the pairing of these two mirror stages, which it sets in strict counterpoint. The first belongs to Sue. Newly emerged, she examines her body before the bathroom mirror in rapt wonder, touching her face, her breasts, her buttocks: the jubilant assumption of the specular image. But Sue is a mirror-stage infant of an uncanny kind. Lacan's infant assumes an image that anticipates a unity it lacks; Sue is the image without the infant, the Ideal-I delivered whole, with no fragmented body behind it. The fragmented body, Lacan's *corps morcelé*, has not been surmounted but exported. It lies unconscious on the floor of the adjoining room, and it will return, at the film's end, as Monstro ElisaSue.

The second mirror stage belongs to Elisabeth, and it occurs in the film's most devastating sequence. Having arranged to meet Fred, a former schoolmate whose regard for her is entirely unappraising, she prepares herself before the mirror. Repeatedly she applies her makeup, steps back, looks out at the billboard of Sue, returns to the mirror, removes the makeup, reapplies it, and at last smears it across her face with her hand and stays at home. This is Woodward's concept enacted with almost clinical precision: the refusal of the specular image, culminating in a self-defacement. A third mirror presides over both stages: the vast photograph of the young Elisabeth that dominates her living room, the Ideal-I fixed to the wall as a permanent reproach.

2.6 Split Embodiment: Young, Leder, Merleau-Ponty

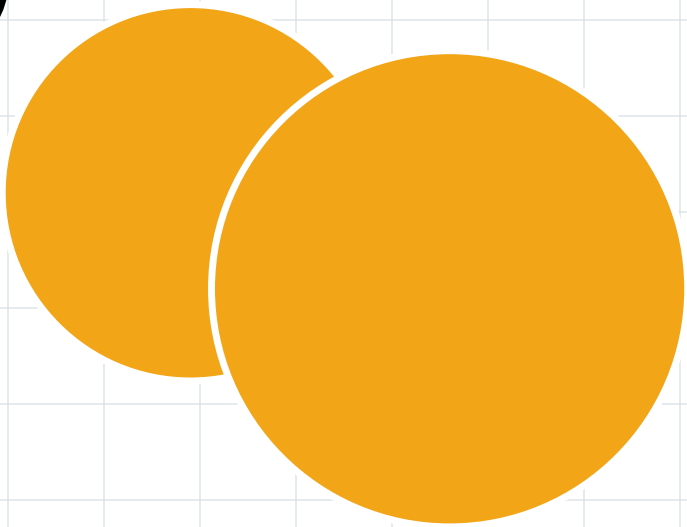
Iris Marion Young's "Pregnant Embodiment" (1984) describes pregnancy as an experience of split subjectivity in which the body is lived as both oneself and not oneself, its inner movements belonging to another being yet felt as one's own. Elisabeth's convulsions on the bathroom floor after the activator are a labour, and Fargeat films them as one. Yet the dorsal birth has removed everything Young found ethically generative in pregnancy: the

mother is unconscious at the moment of birth, the child is born adult, and the relation between them is not gestation but extraction. Young's earlier essay "Throwing Like a Girl" (1980) argued that feminine bodily existence is marked by the experience of living one's body as a thing that is looked at, and the Substance externalizes that thinghood into a separate body.

Drew Leder's *The Absent Body* (1990) observes that the healthy body recedes from awareness in its functioning and "dys-appears," appears as a problem, in pain and dysfunction. The film distributes these modes across its two bodies in a chiasmus of visibility. Sue's body is absent to herself, the transparent instrument of a young person, and hyper-present to others. Elisabeth's body dys-appears to her ever more insistently and is invisible to everyone else. The visibility that society grants and the self-awareness that pain compels never coincide in the same body.

Finally, Merleau-Ponty's late ontology of the flesh, in *The Visible and the Invisible* (1964), takes as its exemplary phenomenon the reversibility of touching and being touched, as when one hand touches the other. The Substance divides that reversibility between two bodies and breaks it. Sue touches the matrix (to suture it, to extract from it, at last to kick it to death) and the matrix cannot touch back, because she is unconscious or overpowered. Elisabeth, in her weeks, touches the inert Sue, and Sue cannot feel it. The flesh that can no longer feel itself touched by itself becomes the flesh that strikes itself. The murder is the terminal form of a reversibility that has been severed.

3



Chapter Three

The Working Week of the Image

Marx's working day, gerontophagy, and the abolished Sabbath.

3.1 The Balance as the Normal Working Day

The tenth chapter of the first volume of *Capital* (1867), "The Working-Day," is the most exact political-economic commentary on *The Substance* ever written, and it was written a century and a half before the film. Marx describes the working day as the object of a structural struggle. Capital, which buys labour-power by the day, seeks to extend the day without limit; the worker, whose labour-power is inseparable from a living body, requires time for its restoration. In its blind, unrestrainable passion, its were-wolf hunger for surplus-labour, capital oversteps not only the moral but even the merely physical maximum bounds of the working day. It usurps the time for growth, development, and healthy maintenance of the body. It reduces the sound sleep needed for the restoration, reparation, and refreshment of the bodily powers to just so many hours of torpor as the revival of an organism, absolutely exhausted, renders essential.

The Substance's "balance" is a normal working day: seven days of activity, seven of restoration. Sue's encroachments are its extension, and the matrix's accelerated senescence is the physical deterioration that Marx documented from the English factory reports, in which the lengthened day shortened the working life of the labourer. Even the matrix's unconsciousness corresponds to Marx's torpor: not rest in any human sense but the minimum state of suspended animation from which an exhausted organism can be revived for further use. The film is a parable of the struggle over the working day conducted within a single person, in which the image would work without end and the body must lie down.

The crucial historical lesson of Marx's chapter concerns how that struggle was resolved. The normal working day was not established by the virtue of individual capitalists, each of whom competition compelled to extend it; it was imposed by law, through the Factory Acts, after decades of collective struggle. The Substance privatizes the limit. "Respect the balance" is a rule addressed to an individual conscience, to be kept by self-discipline against every incentive to break it, and the film demonstrates with the inevitability of a theorem that such a limit cannot hold. Harvey rewards each transgression; the market that bids for the image's

time is not a party to the balance. The limit of the working day, Marx's chapter teaches, is secured collectively or not at all. The Conclusion will return to this lesson.

3.2 Dead Labour and the Inversion of the Vampire

In the same chapter Marx supplies his most famous metaphor: capital is dead labour that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks. Sue is dead labour in precisely this sense. She is the accumulated product of Elisabeth's past work (decades of discipline, celebrity, the apartment with its panoramic view, the reputation that still opens doors) congealed into a new body that lives by drawing living fluid from the old one. The vampirism is literal; the fluid is drawn by needle from the spine.

Yet the film inverts the vampire's cultural genealogy, and the inversion is its sharpest insight. Erzsébet Báthory, the Hungarian countess, was accused in 1610 of torturing and killing dozens of girls and young women, most of them servants in her household; she was never brought to trial, servants charged as her accomplices were tried and three of them executed, and she was confined in her castle at Csejte until her death in 1614, though some historians regard the case as politically motivated. The story that she bathed in her victims' blood to preserve her beauty is a later legend: the old feeds on the young. The same direction governs the modern science and pseudo-science of "young blood": heterochronic parabiosis experiments, in which the circulatory systems of old and young mice are surgically joined; commercial ventures offering infusions of young plasma, against which the United States Food and Drug Administration warned in 2019; the widely publicized 2023 regimen in which the technology entrepreneur Bryan Johnson received plasma from his seventeen-year-old son. The fantasy is always that the old can be renewed by the young.

In *The Substance* it is the young that feeds on the old, and the reversal is not an arbitrary twist but a precise diagnosis. In the economy of the image, youth is not the resource; it is the product. Sue already possesses youth. What she needs, and what she consumes, is the accumulated time of the aged body: its reserve, its reputation, its property, its biography, the very years the market

treats as a liability. I name this structure **gerontophagy**. The old body is the mine; the young image is the refinery. The culture's visible contempt for the aged coexists with an invisible dependence upon them. The coincidence of the name Elisabeth with that of the Blood Countess, which I record as resonance rather than intention, marks the inversion with uncanny exactness: here the countess is the one who is bled.

3.3 The Housewife of Herself: Social Reproduction

Marx's analysis contains a blind spot that feminist theory has spent half a century mapping. Labour-power is reproduced somewhere, by someone: fed, cleaned, rested, consoled, and in the long run replaced by children. Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Selma James in *The Power of Women and the Subversion of the Community* (1972), Silvia Federici in *Wages Against Housework* (1975), and the theorists of social reproduction gathered by Tithi Bhattacharya (2017) argued that this reproductive labour, performed overwhelmingly by women and unwaged, is not outside capitalist production but its hidden condition.

The old body is the mine; the young image is the refinery.

The Substance is a drama of social reproduction collapsed into one life. Elisabeth's weeks are reproductive time: recovery, domestic maintenance, and, increasingly, a spiteful disordering of the space Sue will inherit. In the protocol's terms she is the reserve whose upkeep makes Sue's productive week possible; she is the housewife of her own image. Beauvoir, in *The Second Sex* (1949), compared housework to the torture of Sisyphus: the clean becomes soiled, the soiled is made clean, over and over, day after day. The film reproduces that cycle in the hostile correspondence the two selves conduct through the condition in which each leaves the apartment for the other. And the protocol's requirement that the inactive matrix be nourished figures the dependency work that Eva Feder Kittay, in *Love's Labor* (1999), placed at the foundation of a just society: the care owed to those who cannot, for the time being, care for themselves. Kittay's principle of *doulia*, that those who care

for dependents must themselves be sustained, names exactly what Sue refuses. Her neglect of the matrix is the image economy's refusal to fund its own reproduction.

Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) adds a historical depth that the film's prosthetics make visible. The early modern witch-hunts, in which secular and church courts across Europe tried, tortured, and executed tens of thousands of people between the fifteenth and eighteenth centuries, most of them women, were for Federici integral to primitive accumulation: they disciplined the female body as a new commons to be enclosed, and they fell with particular force upon older, poorer women, whose independence and knowledge marked them as dangerous. As the matrix ages under extraction, the film's makeup design draws unmistakably upon the iconographic archive of the witch: the hump, the gnarled hand, the drooping eye, the solitary woman hidden in a back room. Hypostatic capital produces its crone, and then hides her.

3.4 The Abolished Sabbath: Rest and Sleep

The week is the oldest unit of the rhythm of labour and rest, and its seventh day, in the Hebrew Bible, is the Sabbath, on which creation itself rests. Abraham Joshua Heschel described the Sabbath as a palace in time, a sanctuary in which one ceases to acquire and produce and simply is. The Substance retains the seven-day unit and abolishes the Sabbath. Each self's week of rest is the other's week of labour, and the matrix's "rest" is not rest but storage: unconsciousness on a tiled floor, sustained by tube, in a state indistinguishable from coma. No day belongs to neither self.

Jonathan Crary's *24/7: Late Capitalism and the Ends of Sleep* (2013) argues that sleep is the last natural barrier capitalism has failed fully to colonize, a stretch of time in which nothing is produced or consumed, and that contemporary capitalism is engaged in a sustained assault upon it. The Substance completes the assault. The matrix's sleep is not a refuge from value but its reservoir: the hours in which the body lies still are the hours in which the image draws upon it. Sleep has become a stockpile.

3.5 The Achievement-Subject and the Marketing Personality

Byung-Chul Han's *The Burnout Society* (2010) argues that the disciplinary society Foucault analyzed has given way to an achievement society, whose subject is not coerced by external authority but exploits itself in the name of freedom and self-realization, becoming perpetrator and victim at once. The figure could hardly be more literal than in *The Substance*. Exploiter and exploited are the same person in two bodies; the extraction is voluntary; its language is self-improvement; its outcome, in Elisabeth's binges and isolation, is burnout. Han's *Saving Beauty* (2015) identified the smooth as the aesthetic signature of the present, a beauty purged of negativity, injury, and resistance. Sue's poreless skin is the smooth; the film's gore is the return of everything the smooth excludes: the scar, the pore, the wound, the gash.

Erich Fromm's humanist psychoanalysis anticipated the structure half a century earlier. In *Man for Himself* (1947) Fromm described the "marketing orientation," in which persons experience themselves as commodities whose value is determined by success on the personality market, so that self-esteem depends on conditions beyond their control; he condensed the attitude into a phrase borrowed from Pirandello, "I am as you desire me." Sue is that phrase made flesh, a self manufactured to specification. Arlie Russell Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983) named the emotional labour required of workers whose product is a feeling, and the aerobics host's relentless smile is such labour. Sianne Ngai, in *Our Aesthetic Categories* (2012), identified the zany as the aesthetic category of strenuous, precarious performance in which labour and play become indistinguishable; the aerobics programme, with its frantic cheer and punishing repetition, is the zany at its most literal.

The genre carries its own history. The televised and home-video workout of the 1980s, of which Jane Fonda's *Workout* (1982) is the emblem, promoted fitness as the moral achievement of the self-managing individual. Elisabeth's programme belongs to that moment, and its persistence into the film's present marks the aerobic body as the prototype of the neoliberal one.

3.6 The Pharmacopornographic Kit

Paul B. Preciado's *Testo Junkie* (2008) proposed that post-Fordist capitalism governs subjectivity through a "pharmacopornographic" regime, in which the biomolecular management of bodies (hormones, pharmaceuticals, surgery) and the semiotic-technical production of desire (pornography, media, the image) operate as a single apparatus. The Substance kit is the perfect pharmacopornographic commodity: an injectable that produces a body for the television camera. Its two components correspond exactly to Preciado's two terms. The activator and the stabilizer manage the body biochemically; the aerobics programme consumes it semiotically.

Preciado extends Foucault, and *Discipline and Punish* (1975) remains the genealogy of the aerobic body. Foucault described the docile body produced by the timetable, the drill, and the exercise, its gestures decomposed and recomposed for efficiency; the aerobics routine is the drill set to music. Sandra Lee Bartky, in "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power" (1988), observed that Foucault had ignored the disciplines specific to femininity (dieting, exercise, cosmetics, deportment) and argued that a panoptical male connoisseur resides within the consciousness of most women, who stand perpetually before his gaze and under his judgment. Susan Bordo's *Unbearable Weight* (1993) read the slender body as a text of culture. Naomi Wolf's *The Beauty Myth* (1990) described beauty as a currency system whose function is political, and figured it as an Iron Maiden: the torture device shaped like a woman that encloses its victim within an idealized female form. The matrix in her tiled chamber, enclosed beneath the image she has generated, is Wolf's Iron Maiden rendered as a body.

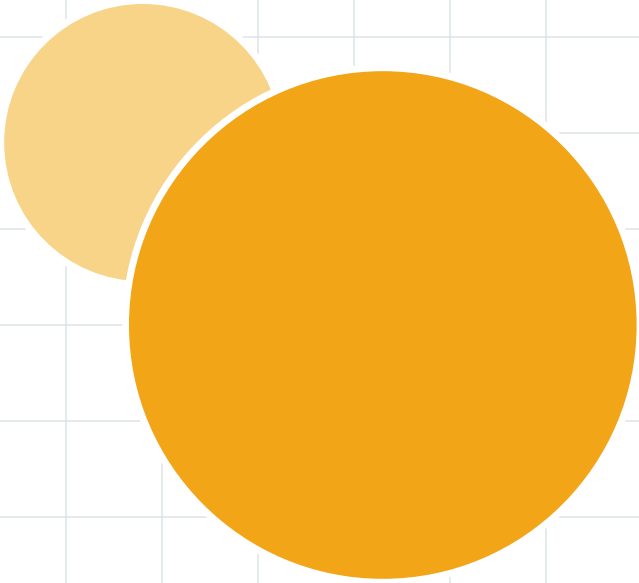
3.7 Aged by Culture: The Expiry Date and Ovarian Time

Susan Sontag's "The Double Standard of Aging" (1972) argued that aging disqualifies women socially and sexually far earlier than it disqualifies men: men are permitted to mature, while women merely age. Harvey is the double standard incarnate. He is coarse,

aged, grotesquely filmed, and entirely secure; nobody proposes his replacement. Gullette's *Aged by Culture* (2004) theorized the decline ideology through which a culture teaches its members to experience the life course as loss, and Elisabeth is aged by Harvey's decision before any wrinkle has registered it.

The threshold of fifty is not arbitrary. It approximates the median age of menopause, the point at which patriarchal biomedicine has historically declared women's reproductive value at an end. The film transposes that reproductive threshold into a representational one, and it answers with a post-menopausal birth: a reproduction that circumvents the womb and issues from the back. The egg prologue, with its rhyme on the iconography of assisted reproduction, now discloses its full sense. The Substance is to representational value what reproductive technology promises to be to biological value: a technique for postponing a woman's expiry date. The opening image is ovarian time, pierced and doubled.

4



Chapter Four

Matrix, Mirror, Matricide

The double, abjection, and an Oresteia of the image.

4.1 The Double: From Insurance to Harbinger

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger*, first published as an essay in 1914 and expanded into a book in 1925, traced the double through literature, folklore, and anthropology, and concluded that it originated as an insurance against the destruction of the ego before reversing its sign to become a harbinger of death. Freud adopted the argument in "The Uncanny" (1919). The double, born of the boundless self-love of primary narcissism as an energetic denial of the power of death, becomes, once that stage is surmounted, an uncanny messenger of the very death it was invented to deny. *The Substance* traverses Rank's entire arc within a single narrative. Sue begins as insurance: a renewed career, a second youth, a denial of the decline Harvey has decreed. She ends as harbinger, the agent of Elisabeth's death and then of her own.

Freud's definition of the uncanny as that species of the frightening which leads back to what is known of old and long familiar applies with literal force. Sue is the familiar returned: the young Elisabeth of the living-room photograph, walking. The footnote on the train, in which Freud fails to recognize his own aged reflection (Chapter Two), and the essay's theory of the double are thus two halves of a single structure, and Fargeat's film unites them: the self that does not recognize its aged image, and the self that recognizes its young image only too well.

4.2 Aggressivity and the Struggle to the Death

Lacan's essay on aggressivity in psychoanalysis (1948) argued that the ego's relation to its specular double is constitutively rivalrous. Because the ego is formed through identification with an image, the other who occupies that image is experienced as a usurper, and the imaginary relation tends toward the formula "you or me." The escalating hostility between Sue and Elisabeth, which begins with notes and soiled kitchens and ends in murder, follows this logic exactly. Each experiences the other as the thief of her place.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) supplies the structure of the outcome. Two self-consciousnesses enter a struggle for recognition; the one that

will not risk death becomes the bondsman and labours for the lord, who enjoys the products of that labour. But the lord's independence is illusory: her enjoyment is mediated entirely by the bondsman's work, and the truth of the independent consciousness turns out to be the servile one. Sue is the lord; the matrix, who sustains, supplies, and maintains, is the bondsman. The film radicalizes Hegel in two respects. Sue depends upon the matrix not merely for recognition and for the products of labour but for metabolism itself: the matrix *is* her stabilizer. And when the struggle ends, as Hegel insisted it must not, in the death of one party, the victor destroys the condition of her own existence. Hegel called such an outcome an abstract negation, which abolishes the other without preserving what it supersedes. In Sue's case the abstract negation of the bondsman is, within days, the decomposition of the lord, whose teeth and nails begin to fall away in a sequence that unmistakably recalls the disintegration of Seth Brundle in Cronenberg's *The Fly* (1986).

4.3 Abjection and Projective Disgust

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defined the abject as that which is neither subject nor object, which disturbs identity, system, and order, and which must be expelled for the subject to constitute its "clean and proper" body: bodily fluids, refuse, food loathing, the corpse. *The Substance* catalogues the abject with encyclopedic rigour: the yolk, the spinal fluid, the shrimp shells cracked between Harvey's teeth, the raw meat of Elisabeth's binge, the blood. Sue's clean and proper body requires the expulsion of the matrix into a hidden room. But the expelled is the condition of the expelling body's existence; the abject cannot be discarded, because it is the source. Kristeva's model of a subject formed through abjection is placed under a strain it was not designed to bear. What if the abject is not the waste of the body but its reserve?

Martha Nussbaum's *Hiding from Humanity* (2004) adds a liberal-humanist account of disgust that converges with Kristeva's psychoanalytic one. Disgust, Nussbaum argued, expresses a refusal of our own animality and mortality, which we project onto subordinated groups, women prominent among them, so that they bear in our place the stigma of embodiment. She set this account

against Leon Kass's claim, in "The Wisdom of Repugnance" (1997), that disgust may express a wisdom deeper than argument. Sara Ahmed's *The Cultural Politics of Emotion* (2004) added that disgust is performative: it sticks to the bodies it recoils from and, in recoiling, constitutes them as disgusting. Fargeat's film can be read as a dramatized adjudication of this dispute. It produces disgust of extraordinary intensity and then discloses the object of disgust as the spectator's own future. Every spectator will age; few will become Sue. The film's disgust is reflexive, turned back upon the disgusted.

It matters that the film's first spectacle of disgust is male appetite. Harvey's lunch, at which he devours shrimp in deforming close-ups while informing Elisabeth that she is finished, assigns the abject first to the patriarch's mouth. Susan Bordo observed that consumer culture codes male appetite as hearty and female appetite as secret, shameful, and dangerous. Fargeat reverses the assignment for one scene and then shows how completely Elisabeth has internalized the original code. When she binges, she experiences her hunger as degradation; when Harvey eats, he experiences his as entitlement.

4.4 Matricide: Kristeva, Irigaray, and the Oresteia of the Image

The matrix is the mother, and Sue's killing of Elisabeth is a matricide. Psychoanalytic feminism offers two opposed accounts of what such an act means. In *Black Sun* (1987), Kristeva argued that matricide is our vital necessity: psychic separation from the maternal object is the condition of individuation, and depression is the failure to accomplish it. Luce Irigaray, in "Body Against Body: In Relation to the Mother" (1981), argued instead that Western culture is founded on the murder of the mother, a murder more archaic than the parricide Freud placed at the origin of culture in *Totem and Taboo* (1913), and that this founding violence must be acknowledged rather than repeated.

The Substance stages the convergence of the two positions, and it is this convergence that I call a **matricidal ontology**. Sue never accomplishes the symbolic matricide Kristeva described. She cannot separate from the matrix, since she is metabolically bound to her; her literal killing of Elisabeth is the acting-out of a

separation that has failed at the symbolic level, and because the separation was never achieved, the killing destroys her too. At the same time, the act repeats exactly the foundational violence Irigaray identified, and the film supplies the institutions that ratify it.

Irigaray's paradigm is Aeschylus' *Oresteia* (458 BCE). Orestes kills his mother Clytemnestra; pursued by the Erinyes, the ancient female avengers of kindred blood, he is tried before Athena's newly founded court on the Areopagus. Apollo's defence rests on an embryology: the mother is not the true parent of what is called her child but only the nurse of the newly sown seed, and the true parent is the father. Athena, born from the head of Zeus without a mother, casts the deciding vote for acquittal and declares herself wholly for the father. The Erinyes are then persuaded to accept a dwelling beneath the city and a new name, the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones.

The Substance's protocol is Apollo's embryology made into a product. The matrix is not the parent of the self; she is its nurse, a nutritive vessel whose function is to sustain what grows from her and whose claims are void. Sue is an Athena of the spectacle: born from her mother's body yet belonging wholly to the father's order of network, executives, and camera. Harvey and his boardroom of elders are the court that ratifies the matricide by rewarding it, and the New Year's Eve broadcast is the civic festival of the acquitted. What the film refuses is Aeschylus' settlement. Monstro ElisaSue is the return of the Erinyes: the hideous, ancient, blood-dripping female figure who pursues the matricide and curses the city that acquitted it. Fargeat's single radical alteration is to fuse matricide and Fury in one body. The avenger is the murderer; the curse is self-directed; and when the creature becomes a fountain of blood that drenches the audience, the Furies' curse falls upon the polis that sanctioned the crime. No Athena intervenes to domesticate the Fury into a Kindly One. The remnant finds its own dwelling beneath the feet of the city, on a pavement star, and the city washes it away.

4.5 Snow White Inverted

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar opened *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) with a reading of the Grimms' "Snow White" as a drama between two women, the plotting Queen and the passive maiden, presided over by the voice in the mirror, which they identified as the patriarchal voice of judgment that rules the Queen's, and every woman's, self-evaluation. Angel and monster are, in their reading, the two images patriarchy offers women. *The Substance* rewrites the tale from inside. The Queen is Elisabeth; the beautiful young woman is Sue; the voice in the mirror is the Substance's impassive male operator and, behind him, Harvey.

No Athena intervenes to domesticate the Fury into a Kindly One.

The film also restores, knowingly or not, the Grimms' first edition of 1812, in which the jealous queen is not a stepmother but Snow White's own mother, a detail the brothers softened in the edition of 1819. Here too the rival beauty is the older woman's offspring. But the beauty that supplants this Queen is her own creation, and the cannibalism is reversed: the Grimm Queen orders the girl's lungs and liver brought to her and believes she has eaten them, whereas in the film it is the girl who feeds upon the Queen.

Two further details of the Grimm text acquire new force. The Queen's murder weapons are instruments of beauty: a stay-lace pulled tight about the girl's bodice, a poisoned comb, an apple. The Substance kit, with its syringes and its promise, belongs to this armoury of lethal cosmetics. And the Queen's death takes place at the wedding feast, where she is made to put on red-hot iron shoes and dance until she falls dead. The New Year's Eve broadcast is that wedding feast, and Monstro's appearance on its stage is that dance: the aged woman compelled to perform before a celebrating court until she is destroyed.

4.6 The Monstrous Spine and the Senile Pregnant Hag

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) argued that the horror film represents woman as monstrous chiefly in relation to her reproductive functions: the archaic mother, the monstrous womb, the possessed body, the castrating woman. Her exemplary monstrous womb is that of Nola Carveth in Cronenberg's *The Brood* (1979), who externalizes her rage as children grown in a sac outside her body. *The Substance* relocates the monstrous womb to the spine. Its monstrosity is post-reproductive: it concerns a woman past the threshold of reproductive value who reproduces not children but her own image, and its organ is the axis of standing rather than the organ of gestation. Sue is, in Cronenberg's idiom, the psychoplasmic offspring of Elisabeth's self-contempt.

Mikhail Bakhtin, in *Rabelais and His World* (completed 1940, published 1965), described the terracotta figurines from Kerch of senile pregnant hags, who laugh. For Bakhtin they were the perfect image of the grotesque body: ambivalent and unfinished, combining death and birth, decrepitude and conception, a pregnant death that gives birth. The matrix of *The Substance* is the senile pregnant hag of late modernity. But where Bakhtin's grotesque is regenerative, belonging to the collective and immortal body of the people renewing itself in carnival laughter, Fargeat's grotesque is commodified: the old woman gives birth not to renewal but to replication, not to the new but to the already valued. Mary Russo, in *The Female Grotesque* (1994), observed that Bakhtin did not reckon with the gendering of his image, and proposed the female grotesque as a site of risk and political possibility. Monstro ElisaSue is the female grotesque at its terminal limit, and the question the film bequeaths to feminist theory is whether the hags can be made to laugh again.

5

Chapter Five

The Mirror Made Transportable

The Substance as cinematic apparatus, and the genealogy of the discarded star.

5.1 Benjamin and Pirandello: The Separable Image

In “The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility” (1935–36), Walter Benjamin quoted Pirandello’s novel *Shoot!* (*Si gira*, 1915), whose narrator describes the film actor as exiled not only from the stage but from himself: the actor’s body loses its corporeality, evaporates, and is transformed into a mute image that flickers for an instant on the screen and vanishes into silence. Benjamin commented that the estrangement the actor feels before the camera is of the same kind as the estrangement felt before one’s own image in a mirror; but now the reflected image has become separable, transportable, and it is transported before the public.

No sentence in the theoretical literature describes *The Substance* more exactly. Sue is Elisabeth’s mirror image made separable and transportable, carried out of the apartment and placed before the public, while Elisabeth remains behind in Pirandellian exile, her body losing its social corporeality as its image flourishes elsewhere. Benjamin added that the film industry responds to the shrivelling of the aura with an artificial build-up of personality outside the studio, the cult of the movie star, which preserves not the unique aura of the person but the phony spell of a commodity. Benjamin hoped that the decay of the aura might prove politically emancipatory. Fargeat records a different outcome. The aura lost to mechanical reproduction is restored by biochemical reproduction: Sue possesses an artificial aura, the singular presence of a body that is nevertheless a copy.

5.2 The Mummy and the Ka: Bazin and Morin

André Bazin’s “Ontology of the Photographic Image” (1945) proposed that if the plastic arts were put under psychoanalysis, the practice of embalming the dead might prove a fundamental factor in their creation. Egyptian religion, directed against death, made survival depend upon the material continuity of the body; the first Egyptian statue was a mummy. From this “mummy complex” Bazin traced the impulse of representation to preserve being through appearance, and he regarded photography as its fulfilment, an art

that embalms time. Edgar Morin's *Le Cinéma ou l'homme imaginaire* (1956) argued that cinema revives the archaic belief in the double, a belief whose most elaborate historical form is the Egyptian *ka*: the double of the living person, which survives death on condition that it possesses a material support, the preserved body or its statue, and is sustained by offerings of food.

Placed side by side, Bazin and Morin describe the Substance with startling precision. The matrix is a mummy: preserved, motionless, sustained by tube in a tiled chamber that is, in all but name, a tomb. Sue is the *ka*: the double that lives on condition that the preserved body persists and is nourished. The Egyptian arrangement is reversed in one respect, and the reversal is decisive. In Egypt the living fed the *ka* through offerings at the tomb; in the Substance the *ka* feeds upon the mummy. The film literalizes the origin myth of the image that Bazin proposed and discloses its economic truth: the image does not preserve the body; it consumes it.

The funerary art of Roman Egypt supplies an image for the film's finale. The Fayum portraits, painted on wooden panels between the first and third centuries and bound into the wrappings over the faces of mummified bodies, represented the dead as they had appeared in life, often idealized and youthful, laid over the desiccated corpse. Monstro ElisaSue, attending the broadcast with a photograph of Elisabeth's younger face cut out and worn over its own, is a Fayum mummy walking: an idealized portrait of youth bound over a ruined body and offered to the gaze of the living.

5.3 The Diva and the Grandmother: Kracauer and Barthes

Siegfried Kracauer's essay "Photography" (1927) opens with the photograph of a film diva, twenty-four years old, on the cover of an illustrated magazine, and sets beside it a sixty-year-old photograph of a grandmother as a young woman. The grandmother's photograph, Kracauer argued, no longer communicates the person; it shows a costume, a coiffure, a fashion, the residue of a moment from which the person has departed, and it provokes both laughter and a shudder. *The Substance* stages Kracauer's diptych along the axis of a single life. The diva is on the billboard; the grandmother, the matrix, is the residue the photograph has emptied.

The image does not preserve the body; it consumes it.

Roland Barthes's "The Face of Garbo," in *Mythologies* (1957), described Garbo's face as an Idea rather than an Event, a mask of snowy, plaster-like perfection. Barthes observed that where other actresses consented to let the crowd watch the ominous maturing of their beauty, Garbo would not: the essence was not to be degraded, and it was progressively veiled by dark glasses, broad hats, and exile, but never seen to deteriorate. Garbo chose the matrix's seclusion so that the image might remain unaged. Monstro's paper mask carries Barthes's analysis to its conclusion: the face as Idea, cut quite literally out of a picture and pasted over the Event of a body. Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) located the essence of photography in the *that-has-been*, the certainty that the photographed person was there, and therefore in death. The giant portrait in Elisabeth's living room is a that-has-been presiding over the apartment like a funerary image. Elisabeth lives in her own mausoleum.

5.4 The Star as Text: Morin, Dyer, and the Casting

Morin's *Les Stars* (1957) analyzed the star as a modern demigod, a double of the actor raised to semi-divinity by the system that produces it. Richard Dyer's *Stars* (1979) and *Heavenly Bodies* (1986) theorized the star image as a structured polysemy: an intertext of films, publicity, promotion, and commentary, which every new performance activates. *The Substance* is constructed so as to mobilize its stars' intertexts. Demi Moore's image condenses four decades of negotiation between an actress and the public body: the romantic centrality of *Ghost* (1990); the nude, pregnant cover of *Vanity Fair* photographed by Annie Leibovitz (1991); the public scrutiny of her remuneration for *Striptease* (1996); the shaved head and athletic discipline of *G.I. Jane* (1997); her return, as an older former Angel among younger ones, in *Charlie's Angels: Full Throttle* (2003); and the memoir *Inside Out* (2019), which recounts the bodily discipline the industry demanded and she internalized. Moore's younger images circulate permanently in the culture as Sue-like

doubles, and the casting makes the film a document of the condition it depicts.

The casting extends the structure in two further directions. Margaret Qualley is the daughter of Andie MacDowell, an actress who has spoken publicly of her decision to stop dyeing her greying hair, so that the real daughter of an aging star plays the image-daughter of an aging star. And the role of Harvey was reportedly intended for Ray Liotta before his death in 2022, after which Dennis Quaid assumed it. The production was itself marked by the substitution of one aging male star for another, and in the case of men the substitution provoked no narrative of decline.

The executive's name carries a further charge. A film made after 2017 can hardly call the man who controls an actress's employment Harvey without evoking Harvey Weinstein, the producer whose sexual harassment and assault of women who depended on him for work was exposed by *The New York Times* and *The New Yorker* in October 2017, and who was convicted of rape in Los Angeles in 2022. I record the echo as resonance rather than intention, as with the film's other names; what it adds is the documented history of what an executive's appraisal of actresses has licensed.

5.5 Spectacle, Simulacrum, Pavement

Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images, and described the celebrity as the spectacular representation of a living human being, who embodies a possible role at the cost of renouncing autonomy. Jean Baudrillard's *The Consumer Society* (1970) called the body the finest consumer object, invested with narcissistic care as a form of capital; his *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) theorized the precession of simulacra, a regime in which the copy precedes and engenders the real. *The Substance* occupies the point at which these theories converge. Sue is a simulacrum that has displaced its referent; the original survives only as the waste product of its copy.

The Walk of Fame completes the argument. Inaugurated in 1960, it consecrates celebrity by setting it into the pavement, beneath the crowd. It is the most literal monument ever erected to the hypostatic structure of fame: the star is that upon which others

stand. The film opens and closes upon it. In the opening montage the star is laid and then trodden; in the finale the remnant of Elisabeth lies down upon it and becomes, in the most literal sense available to cinema, the substance of her own celebrity, before a machine washes it into the gutter.

5.6 Genealogy: The Discarded Star and Her Monsters

The film's generic ancestry is unusually dense, and its relation to that ancestry is itself an argument. Billy Wilder's *Sunset Boulevard* (1950) gave Hollywood its founding image of the discarded star. Norma Desmond insists that she is still big and that it is the pictures that have grown small, and her final descent of the staircase toward the newsreel cameras, in the delusion of a long-awaited close-up, is the direct ancestor of Monstro's march onto the stage. Joseph L. Mankiewicz's *All About Eve* (1950) staged the usurpation of an aging star by her young admirer and closed on an image of infinite substitution: a still younger girl holding Eve's award before a triple mirror that multiplies her reflection into a series. *The Substance* internalizes Eve into Margo: the usurper is self-generated, and the series is a single life.

Robert Aldrich's *What Ever Happened to Baby Jane?* (1962) inaugurated the cycle critics have called "Grande Dame Guignol" and, less kindly, "hagsploitation," in which aging female stars no longer offered glamorous roles were recast as grotesques and murderers. The cycle's own economy enacted the Substance's logic: the aging actress was converted into a monster because the industry had no other use for her. *The Substance* reactivates the cycle in order to expose the conversion, and I call its position **dialectical hagsploitation**. It makes its aging star monstrous in order to indict the economy that makes aging stars monstrous, and it cannot wholly escape the pleasure the genre has always taken in the spectacle.

The B-movie lineage is closer still. In Roger Corman's *The Wasp Woman* (1959), the aging head of a cosmetics firm, whose falling sales are attributed to her own fading face, injects herself with an enzyme serum, grows young, and becomes periodically monstrous. In *The Leech Woman* (1960), an aging wife restores her youth with a secretion drawn from the pineal glands of men and must kill

repeatedly to sustain the effect; the extraction of a fluid from the central nervous system of another body is the direct precursor of the Substance's spinal harvest. Tony Scott's *The Hunger* (1983) staged the catastrophic aging of a vampire's companion. Robert Zemeckis's *Death Becomes Her* (1992) imagined an immortality potion whose users must perpetually repair their deteriorating bodies, immortality as endless maintenance labour. John Frankenheimer's *Seconds* (1966) sold its protagonist a new and younger identity from a faceless corporation that ultimately recycles him as a cadaver for its next client. Vivian Sobchack's essay "Scary Women: Cinema, Surgery, and Special Effects" (1999) remains the most penetrating account of this tradition: the special effect as the cinematic articulation of women's dread of aging and of the surgical remedies sold against it.

The auteur cinema of the uncanny supplies further coordinates. In Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980), Jack Torrance embraces a beautiful young woman from the bath of Room 237 and discovers, first in the mirror and then in his arms, that she is a rotting old woman. That scene is the canonical cinematic formulation of misogynist horror at the aging female body, and *The Substance* reworks it from inside the bathroom: what was a man's nightmare becomes a woman's experience of being that nightmare. The film's symmetrical corridors and saturated institutional interiors declare the Kubrickian debt openly. Its white bathroom, in which an old body lies while a new being is born, recalls the terminal room of *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), where Bowman sees himself age, die, and return as the Star Child, and it turns that transcendence into a consumer product. Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960) is itself a matricide narrative: Norman Bates has poisoned his mother and her lover, keeps her preserved corpse in the house, and murders Marion Crane while dressed as her. Monstro, wearing the face of the woman Sue killed, repeats that structure in the feminine, the child who kills the mother and then appears before others in her likeness, and the hidden room in which the matrix lies is the Bates cellar. Georges Franju's *Eyes Without a Face* (1960) made the transplanted face and the expressionless mask its central images, and its plot is an extraction economy: the surgeon Génessier, with his assistant Louise, abducts young women and removes their faces

in failed attempts to graft them onto his disfigured daughter, Christiane. Ingmar Bergman's *Persona* (1966), whose actress protagonist is named Elisabet and whose most famous shot fuses two women's faces into one, is the art-cinema precedent for the composite name and body of Monstro ElisaSue. Darren Aronofsky's *Requiem for a Dream* (2000) follows Sara Goldfarb, a widow who, hoping to appear on television in a dress she can no longer fit, is prescribed amphetamine diet pills, descends into psychosis, and ends committed to a psychiatric hospital and subjected to electroconvulsive therapy: a pharmaceutical route to the televisual body that anticipates the Substance kit. His *Black Swan* (2010) set a young dancer's ascent against the despair of Beth, the aging principal whom the company's director forces into retirement and who later turns a nail file on her own face.

The body-horror coordinates are explicit. *The Fly* supplies the decomposition; *The Brood* the rage-birth; *Videodrome* (1983) the seductive media object that enters the body, here a drive slipped into a coat pocket; *Dead Ringers* (1988) the twinship of a single self. David Lynch's *The Elephant Man* (1980) supplies the deformed body displayed upon a stage and its demand for recognition; Brian De Palma's *Carrie* (1976) the stage humiliation, in which Chris Hargensen and Billy Nolan drench Carrie in pig's blood at the moment she is crowned prom queen, and her retaliation, in which she kills many of those present; here the direction of the blood is reversed, so that the woman drenches the crowd; Peter Jackson's *Braindead* (1992) the hyperbolic geyser of gore and a monstrous mother who would reabsorb her son into her body; Brian Yuzna's *Society* (1989) a ritual, which the film calls the shunting, in which the rich literally absorb the bodies of the poor. Fargeat's own work completes the lineage. *Reality+* (2014) imagined the time-limited technological perfection of appearance; *Revenge* (2017) is a rape-revenge film, the genre Carol Clover analyzed alongside the slasher: its heroine, Jen, is raped by Stan, one of her married lover's friends, while a second friend, Dimitri, looks away; her lover, Richard, then pushes her from a cliff to silence her and leaves her for dead; she cauterizes her own wound, branding a phoenix into her skin, and kills all three men, the last of them naked in a house awash in blood, so that the exposure the camera usually reserves

for women is turned on the man. The French corporeal cinema to which James Quandt gave the name "New French Extremity" (2004), together with the feminist body cinema of Marina de Van's *In My Skin* (2002) and Julia Ducournau's *Raw* (2016) and *Titane* (2021), is the milieu in which an English-language Hollywood satire by a French director could become a philosophical film.

5.7 Body Genres and the Look of the Woman

Linda Williams's "Film Bodies: Gender, Genre, and Excess" (1991) grouped horror, melodrama, and pornography as "body genres," united by the spectacle of a body seized by sensation (fear, sorrow, sexual pleasure) and by the spectator's involuntary mimicry of that sensation; each has its fluid, respectively blood, tears, and sexual fluids. *The Substance* is the rare film that is all three body genres at once. Its aerobics sequences borrow the framings of pornography; its dressing-table sequence is melodrama of the most painful kind; its finale is horror at its most extravagant. The spectator is solicited to arousal, to tears, and to disgust by the same body, and the film thereby demonstrates that the three responses are three modes of a single relation to the female body: the relation of the appraiser.

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the Final Girl, the resourceful survivor of the slasher film, whose survival depends upon her acquisition of masculine attributes. *The Substance* has no Final Girl. Its woman is victim, monster, and survivor at once, and none of the three survives. Williams's earlier essay "When the Woman Looks" (1984) proposed that in classical horror the woman who looks at the monster recognizes a kinship with it, since both are bodies marked as freakish under the male gaze. In *The Substance* the kinship becomes identity. When Elisabeth looks at her aged body, and when the studio audience looks at Monstro, the woman and the monster are the same person.

5.8 The Formless: Horizontality and Entropy

Georges Bataille's entry "Formless" ("Informe") in the critical dictionary of *Documents* (1929) defined the formless not by a meaning but by a task: it is a term that serves to bring things down in the world. Rosalind Krauss and Yve-Alain Bois, in *Formless:* A

User's Guide (1997), organized the operations of the formless under four headings: horizontality, base materialism, pulse, and entropy. The finale of *The Substance* performs all four. Horizontality: the upright figure of billboard and stage is reduced to a puddle on a horizontal star. Base materialism: the geyser of blood and the undifferentiated flesh assert matter beneath form. Pulse: the throbbing rhythm of the aerobics soundtrack and the convulsions of the activator recur as the spasms of the dying creature. Entropy: at dawn the street cleaner disperses what remains.

Michel Foucault ended *The Order of Things* (1966) with the prediction that man, an invention of recent date, might be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The film's last image renders that prophecy with an exactness that may be accidental but is no less complete. A face, the face the culture demanded and then refused, lies upon a pavement, and a machine washes it away. The humanist subject, the face as the seat of personhood, dissolves into the substance that bore it.

6

Chapter Six

After the Dignity of Man

Pico, Kant, Arendt, the posthuman, and the limits of the film's feminism.

6.1 Pico's Chameleon and the Obligation to Fashion Oneself

The humanist charter of self-making is Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (composed 1486). Pico's God, having assigned every other creature a fixed place, gives Adam none: neither a determinate seat nor a form of his own, so that he may, as the free and sovereign maker of himself, fashion himself in whatever shape he prefers. He may degenerate into the lower forms, which are brutish, or be reborn by his own decision into the higher forms, which are divine. Man is the chameleon of creation.

The Substance's advertisement is Pico's oration rewritten as copy. It too promises rebirth into a higher form, younger, more beautiful, more perfect, by the subject's own decision. What the film adds is the discovery that, under hypostatic capital, Pico's alternatives are no longer alternatives. A single transaction produces both outcomes at once: rebirth into the higher form (Sue, angelic and upright) and degeneration into the lower (the matrix, bestialized and bent), and finally, in Monstro, both in one body. Stephen Greenblatt's *Renaissance Self-Fashioning* (1980) observed that Renaissance self-fashioning was achieved in relation to an authority and against something perceived as alien, an other that had to be discovered or invented in order to be attacked and destroyed. Sue fashions herself in relation to the authority of Harvey and the network, and against an alien other, the matrix, who must be hidden and finally destroyed. The freedom of self-fashioning has become the obligation of self-improvement, and the alien other against whom the self is fashioned is the self.

The humanist canon of the body completes the picture. Leonardo's Vitruvian Man inscribed an ideal body within a circle and a square, making its proportions the measure of the cosmos, in the spirit of Protagoras' dictum that man is the measure of all things. Fargeat's symmetrical compositions frame Sue as a Vitruvian ideal, centred and proportioned. Monstro ElisaSue is the anti-Vitruvian body: asymmetrical, multiplied, incommensurable. The humanist ideal of proportion returns as the tyranny of the beauty standard, and its negation returns as horror. In the regime the film depicts, the image is the measure of all things.

6.2 Price and Dignity: Kant and the Equivalent

Kant's *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) distinguishes, in the kingdom of ends, between that which has a price and that which has a dignity. Whatever has a price can be replaced by something else as its equivalent; whatever is raised above all price, and so admits of no equivalent, has a dignity. The ultimate operation of the Substance is the manufacture of an equivalent for a person. Sue is the equivalent through which Elisabeth's dignity is converted into a price, and since Sue in turn can be replaced (her successor is implicit in the logic of the network), the conversion is serial. Kant's formula of humanity, that one must never treat humanity, whether in one's own person or in that of another, merely as a means, is violated in the film in the mode Kant's readers have found hardest to picture: in one's own person, by oneself as another.

Kant himself pictured it, and his examples are uncanny. In the *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797), discussing perfect duties to oneself, he condemned what he called partial self-murder: depriving oneself of an integral part or organ, for instance by giving away or selling a tooth to be transplanted into another's mouth, or by having oneself castrated in order to make an easier living as a singer. The first example describes the economy of the Substance, the transfer of bodily substance from one body to another; the second describes its motive, the mutilation of the body for a career in performance. When the transfer fails, Sue's own teeth begin to fall.

Martha Nussbaum's essay "Objectification" (1995) distinguished seven features of treating a person as a thing: instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, fungibility, violability, ownership, and denial of subjectivity. Rae Langton added reduction to body, reduction to appearance, and silencing. The Substance distributes all ten across a single person. The matrix suffers inertness (she is literally unconscious), violability (she is pierced), ownership (she belongs to "herself"), and instrumentality. Sue suffers fungibility (she is replaceable), reduction to appearance, denial of subjectivity (the network has no interest in her interior), and silencing (her function is to smile). The film thereby presents self-objectification not as a metaphor but as a complete objectifying system internal to

one life: the condition that Barbara Fredrickson and Tomi-Ann Roberts described in psychological terms as "objectification theory" (1997), the internalization of an observer's perspective on one's own body, with its attendant habitual monitoring, shame, and anxiety.

6.3 Existence, Ambiguity, Natality

Sartre's lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (delivered 1945, published 1946) defined the human being as the being whose existence precedes its essence. The Substance reverses the formula. The essence, the market's ideal, is specified in advance, and Sue is called into existence to embody it; she is an essentialist creature living in an existentialist ruin. Beauvoir's *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) argued that the human condition is the ambiguity of being at once subject and object, freedom and facticity, and that bad faith consists in the attempt to flee one term into the other. The Substance hypostatizes the two terms of ambiguity into two bodies, each of which claims exclusivity: Sue the pure object, Elisabeth the pure and unseen subject. The flight from ambiguity is no longer a moral failing; it is a product.

In *Old Age*, Beauvoir called old age a parody of life, and prescribed against it the continued pursuit of ends that give existence meaning: devotion to individuals, to groups, or to causes; social, political, intellectual, or creative work. The world of *The Substance* contains none of these. Elisabeth has no friends, no cause, no work beyond the image, no community; the one person who offers her an unappraising regard, Fred, is the one she cannot bring herself to meet. Monstro is Beauvoir's parody made literal, and its emergence is the consequence of a world without ends.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) located in natality, the fact that human beings are born and can therefore begin something new, the miracle that saves the world from ruin. Arendt distinguished *who* someone is, disclosed only in action and speech, from *what* someone is: the qualities, gifts, and shortcomings a person shares with others of her kind. The Substance offers a counterfeit natality, a birth that begins nothing and reproduces the qualities the market already values. The image economy perceives only the *what*. Monstro's attempt to appear as Elisabeth, wearing her face before an audience, is a desperate claim to be seen as a

who in a world that can see only a *what*, and the audience's horror is that world's verdict.

6.4 Hyperagency and the Posthuman

Michael Sandel's *The Case Against Perfection* (2007) argued that the deepest objection to biotechnological enhancement is not that it violates autonomy but that it expresses a drive to mastery, a hyperagency that forgets the gifted character of human powers and achievements. The Substance is a parable of hyperagency in Sandel's sense: the refusal of the given body and the given life course. Jürgen Habermas's *The Future of Human Nature* (2001) warned that genetic design would install an asymmetry between designer and designed, incompatible with the designed person's sense of being the undivided author of her own life. Sue is a designed person whose designer she must live off, and finally kill. Leon Kass's essays against the pursuit of indefinite youth, and Francis Fukuyama's *Our Posthuman Future* (2002), with its appeal to an essential human "Factor X," represent a conservative humanism the film neither endorses nor refutes. Nick Bostrom's "The Fable of the Dragon-Tyrant" (2005), which figures aging as a monster that humanity has wrongly learned to tolerate, represents the transhumanist position. The film's intervention in this debate is precise. It agrees that aging, in its world, is a catastrophe; it disagrees about the dragon's nature. The dragon is not senescence but the gaze that converts senescence into worthlessness.

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) welcomed the breakdown of the boundaries between organism and machine as an opening for feminist politics, while naming the world system that exploits those breakdowns the "informatics of domination." The Substance is a product of the informatics of domination: a boundary-dissolving technology placed wholly in the service of the norm. N. Katherine Hayles, in *How We Became Posthuman* (1999), criticized the fantasy of disembodied information, consciousness detachable from its material substrate, as an inheritance of liberal humanism. The weekly switch embodies that fantasy, and the film's body horror is the revenge of the substrate. Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) proposed an affirmative ethics grounded in *zoe*, the generative force of life beyond the human subject. The matrix is

zoe captured: bare, nourishing life, harvested for the benefit of an image.

6.5 Feminist Counter-Humanisms

Against Pico's chameleon and the Vitruvian body, feminist thought offers alternative measures of the human that the film invokes by their absence. Ursula K. Le Guin's essay "The Space Crone" (1976) proposed that if visitors from another world asked for a representative human being, we should send an ordinary old woman past menopause, since she has undergone the greatest change a human being can undergo and survived it. Germaine Greer's *The Change* (1991) described the climacteric as a release from the obligation to be desirable, and the crone as a figure of freedom. In the world of *The Substance* neither proposal is thinkable. The crone is visible only as a monster, and release from desirability is experienced only as death.

The dragon is not senescence but the gaze that converts senescence into worthlessness.

Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) argued that the first cultural tool was probably not the spear but the container, the bag in which food was gathered and carried home, and that stories might be told as carrier bags rather than as the trajectories of heroes. The Substance's technology is all needle: it penetrates, extracts, injects. Its matrix is a container treated as a mine. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) declared that one need only look at the Medusa straight on to see her, and that she is not deadly but beautiful, and laughing. Monstro ElisaSue is looked at straight on, by a studio audience and a television public, and is met with screams. The film ends before laughter becomes possible; its open question is whether criticism can supply what the film withholds.

6.6 The Limits of the Film's Feminism

A thesis that reads *The Substance* as a philosophical work owes it a statement of its limits, which are considerable and, I shall argue,

themselves diagnostic. The film's universal woman is white, thin, wealthy, heterosexual, able-bodied, and a celebrity. bell hooks's "The Oppositional Gaze" (1992) observed that Black women spectators, excluded from the ideal that classical cinema offered white women, developed a critical gaze from outside it; for many such spectators, Elisabeth's catastrophe is the loss of a privilege they were never offered. Kimberlé Crenshaw's analysis of intersectionality (1989) clarifies why the film's aging cannot stand for aging as such: the double standard of aging falls differently on women whom the culture never consecrated in the first place. Richard Dyer's *White* (1997) showed how the technologies and conventions of cinematic lighting were calibrated to white skin; Sue's luminous whiteness is the unmarked default of the ideal the film critiques.

Disability studies identifies a deeper tension. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's *Extraordinary Bodies* (1997) and *Staring* (2009) analyzed the freak show and the cultural practice of staring at non-normative bodies, and Robert McRuer's *Crip Theory* (2006) theorized compulsory able-bodiedness. The film's horror depends on the very responses to deformity, disfigurement, and frailty that it ostensibly indicts; its climactic monster is a disabled body displayed upon a stage for an audience's terror. Fat studies would raise a parallel objection to the binge sequences, which mobilize disgust at a woman's appetite to signify her decline.

The most revealing absence is that of women in relation to one another. *The Substance* contains no mothers, daughters, sisters, friends, colleagues, or comrades: only one woman, divided. Tania Modleski's title *Feminism Without Women* (1991), coined for the cultural politics of an emergent postfeminism, describes the film's structure precisely. Nancy Fraser's "Feminism, Capitalism and the Cunning of History" (2009) argued that second-wave ideals of autonomy and self-making were resignified to legitimate neoliberal capitalism. Angela McRobbie's *The Aftermath of Feminism* (2009) named the "post-feminist masquerade," in which hyper-femininity is reframed as free choice. Rosalind Gill's account of the postfeminist sensibility (2007), and Gill and Shani Orgad's *Confidence Culture* (2022), described the injunction to self-optimization that the Substance's advertisement voices almost

word for word. The film's monadic woman is the shape of the neoliberal subject. Its inability to imagine a feminism of more than one woman is not only a limitation of the film; it is an accurate portrait of a world from which solidarity has been subtracted. The Conclusion begins from that subtraction.

Conclusion

Toward a Hypostatic Feminism

Five theses for a feminism of the substratum.

C.1 Recapitulation

This thesis has argued that *The Substance* is a speculative ontology of the substratum. Chapter One showed that the film's commandment, "you are one," compresses the Western metaphysics of identity into a liability clause, and that the narrative traverses that metaphysics from Aristophanes' halves to Parfit's fission. Chapter Two grounded the concept of dorsal natality in a phenomenology of the gaze and of the back, and showed the film to be built upon the counterpoint of two mirror stages. Chapter Three reconstructed the film's political economy as the working week of the image and identified, in its inversion of the vampire, a structure of gerontophagy. Chapter Four read the narrative as a matricide and its finale as an Oresteia of the image. Chapter Five showed the Substance to be the cinematic apparatus rendered biological, and the Walk of Fame to be the literal monument of hypostatic fame. Chapter Six measured the film against the humanist tradition, found in it the completion of self-fashioning as self-replication, and stated the limits of a feminism without women.

C.2 New Year's Eve: A Calendrical Theology

It remains to explain why the catastrophe occurs on New Year's Eve. The popular iconography of the turning year personifies the old year as Father Time, an aged man bearing scythe and hourglass, and the new year as an infant who displaces him at midnight. The iconography is a secularized liturgy of replacement: the old is not mourned but superseded, and the supersession is celebrated as a party. *The Substance* feminizes the allegory and then collapses it. Elisabeth is the old year; Sue is the new; and Monstro, who arrives at the broadcast that was to celebrate the substitution, is both at once, Father Time and the infant year in a single female body.

In Bakhtin's terms the broadcast is a carnival of crowning and uncrowning, in which the year's queen is crowned and destroyed in one ceremony. But it is a carnival owned by a network. The countdown is a product cycle, the year a season, and the celebration a ritual of obsolescence. The film's date makes explicit what the whole has implied: the culture of the image organizes time

itself around the replacement of the old by the new, and calls the replacement festivity.

C.3 Five Theses for a Hypostatic Feminism

If the regime that destroys Elisabeth Sparkle capitalizes the standing figure and charges its costs to the recumbent ground, a feminism adequate to it must be a feminism of the ground. I call it hypostatic feminism and state it in five theses.

1 **The substratum is the condition, not the residue, of the figure.** Apollo's embryology, according to which the mother is merely the nurse of the seed, is the founding lie of hypostatic capital, and the Substance's protocol is its latest edition. Hypostatic feminism begins by refusing it: by insisting, with Irigaray, on a symbolic order that acknowledges the mother rather than murdering her, and, with the theorists of social reproduction, that the labour of the ground (feeding, cleaning, resting, sustaining) is not the shadow of value but its source. In the language of the film: the matrix is not the waste of the self but its condition.

2 **Rest is a right of the ground.** The film demonstrates that the balance cannot be kept by an individual promise, because the market that rewards its violation is not a party to it. Marx's chapter on the working day teaches that the limit was won only by collective law. Hypostatic feminism is accordingly a politics of time, a Sabbath politics, which defends the time of restoration, of sleep, of aging, and of lying down against the image's working week, not as self-discipline but as social right. The balance must be legislated, not merely respected.

3 **The back belongs to the other; the proper relation to the unseen self is care, not gaze.** Dorsal natality revealed that the Substance brings the self to birth from the side of the body that only others can see. The same fact grounds an ethics. No one can see, stitch, or tend her own back; the back is the anatomical proof of interdependence. The film contains a single gesture that could have founded such an ethics: Sue, newly born, closing the wound along Elisabeth's spine. The market converts that suture into

maintenance. Hypostatic feminism extends it into solidarity, in the spirit of Kittay's *doulia*: the care of the unseen by those who are placed to see it.

4

The crone is the measure. Against Protagoras' man who measures all things, against the Vitruvian body and the network's youthful face, hypostatic feminism measures the human from the aged body: from Le Guin's crone, who has survived the greatest change; from Greer's climacteric, which releases women from the obligation of desirability; from Beauvoir's demand that old age be given ends rather than parodied. It would restore Bakhtin's senile pregnant hags to the laughter the Kerch figurines preserve, and Cixous's Medusa to the laughter the film withholds from Monstro.

5

Horizontality can be solidarity rather than dissolution. The film's final operation is horizontal in Bataille's sense: the figure brought down into formless matter. But horizontality has another meaning, the one the film withholds. The image the film repeatedly approaches and never permits is that of the two bodies of one life lying side by side, each sustaining the other; the dinner with Fred, at which Elisabeth would have been regarded without appraisal, is the image of a recognition she cannot accept. To lie alongside, rather than beneath, is the horizontality of solidarity. Hypostatic feminism would extend the balance from the relation of one woman to herself into a relation among women, and among all who age, which the film's monadic structure forecloses.

C.4 Coda: The Star That Is Walked Upon

The film ends at dawn, on a pavement, with a machine. A face that had been demanded, consecrated, cut out, worn, and refused lies upon a star of terrazzo and brass and is washed into the gutter. One may read the image as despair, and the film offers no other reading. But the image also discloses, with the clarity that only literalization affords, what the culture of the image has always stood upon. Beneath every consecrated figure there is a substratum that bears it: the bodies that age so that images need not, the women whose rest is drawn upon so that others may work

without end, the mothers whose claims are dismissed so that the child may belong wholly to the father. *The Substance* names that substratum in its title. The task its spectators inherit is to grant the ground a standing of its own: not to raise the substratum into another figure, but to refuse the vertical economy in which only figures count.

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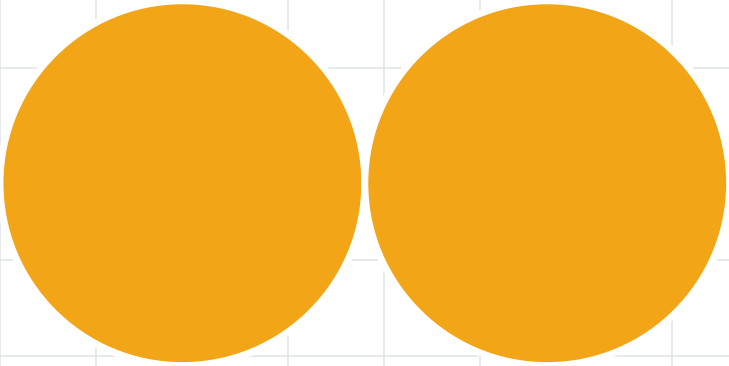
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Keywords

The Substance	mimicry	star studies
Coralie Fargeat	masquerade	Demi Moore
feminist film theory	being-for-others	cinematic apparatus
body horror	phenomenology of the body	mummy complex
hypostatic extraction	abjection	Benjamin
hypostatic capital	disgust	Bazin
dorsal natality	the monstrous-feminine	Morin
hypostatic feminism	matricide	Fayum portraits
liability monism	*Oresteia*	Hollywood Walk of Fame
gerontophagy	Irigaray	Grande Dame Guignol
evaluative proximity	Kristeva	hagsploitation
matricidal ontology	Snow White	body genres
dialectical hagsploitation	the grotesque	Final Girl
substance and hypostasis	Bakhtin	informe
personal identity	aging studies	humanism
fission	ageism	Pico della Mirandola
Locke	double standard of aging	Kant
Parfit	menopause	dignity
Ricoeur	social reproduction	objectification
Jekyll and Hyde	Marx	natality
the double	the working day	Arendt
Doppelgänger	Sabbath	transhumanism
the uncanny	sleep	posthumanism
mirror stage	achievement society	care ethics
mirror stage of old age	pharmacopornography	crone
male gaze	beauty myth	Le Guin
John Berger	postfeminism	Cixous
Laura Mulvey	aesthetic labour	



The task its spectators inherit is to grant the ground a standing of its own.

Sub-Stantia
Dorsal Natality, Hypostatic Capital, and the Matricidal Image in Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance*